

Caves

Caves are underground spaces or holes that are large enough for someone to enter. They form in many different ways, but mostly because of rock in the Earth's surface being worn away or crumbling. Caves usually have lots of interesting and exciting features to explore.

Stalagmite

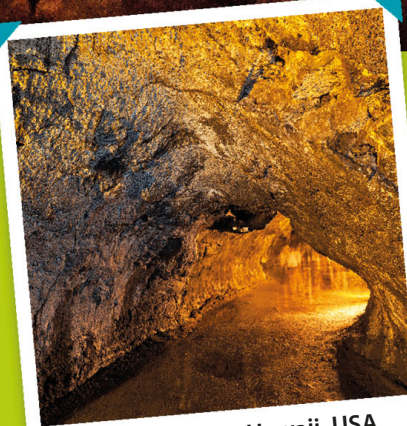
Water dripping onto the cave floor leaves behind tiny rocky particles that were dissolved in it. As the dripping continues, these particles can build up to form a pillar of rock, or stalagmite.

Solutional caves

These are the most common type of cave. They are created when a build up of acidic water dissolves the rock around it. Holes and tunnels start to appear, getting bigger and bigger as more rock dissolves and is washed away.

Types of cave

Caves are found all over our planet. Some are small, single spaces, but others contain many chambers, linked by tunnels to form a huge maze of different areas. Although most caves are found in rock, some form in ice or lava.



Thurston cave, Hawaii, USA

Lava caves

When lava flows slowly over land around a volcano, it can harden on the surface, leaving liquid lava flowing underneath. This liquid drains away, leaving a hollow tube of rock that forms a cave.